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An unlit stretch of Interstate 65 between Alford Avenue and U.S. 31. Photo by David Leong.

By JON ANDERSON

If you're driving on Interstate 459 or Interstate 65 in or around Hoover at night, there's a good chance you'll be driving in the dark.

Many of the interstate streetlights are not working. Hoover officials said they try to keep an eye on outages and address them as they are reported, but there appear to be gaps in the process.

On I-65 in early September, there were 23 interstate streetlights out on the southbound side between Alford Avenue and U.S. 31, three more out between U.S. 31 and I-459, and 10 out between I-459 and Valleydale Road.

On the northbound side of I-65, there were eight streetlights out between Valleydale and I-459, five out between I-459 and U.S. 31, and 21 out between U.S. 31 and Alford Avenue.

On I-459, there were 24 lights out between I-65 and Galleria Boulevard. And there are no

light poles on I-459 south of Galleria Boulevard, except at the bottom of the exit ramps at John Hawkins Parkway.

John Anthony, Hoover's traffic engineer, and Eddie Pickett, Hoover's senior traffic signal technician who keeps an eye on streetlights in key corridors, said they try to spot the lights that are out and address problems that are reported and determined to be Hoover's responsibility.

Pickett reports issues to Anthony, and Anthony gets Stone and Sons Electrical to replace bulbs or make other repairs as needed, they said.

Pickett said it's his understanding that Hoover is responsible for lights on I-459 between I-65 and Galleria Boulevard and on I-65 between Valleydale Road and U.S. 31, as well as some at the intersection of I-65 and Alford Avenue. But he didn't think Hoover was responsible for any between Alford and U.S. 31 on either side of the interstate.

Vestavia Hills officials acknowledge that their city is responsible for some of the lights on I-65 between I-459 and Alford but say Hoover is responsible for many as well, particularly on the southbound side between Alford and U.S. 31.

Lori Beth Kearley, the public services director for Vestavia Hills, said the city wants to tackle the problem with interstate lighting, but it's much more complicated than many people realize.

"It's not just a matter of bulbs being out," Kearley said.

Sometimes, poles get knocked down. Other times, it's a problem with the wiring, a fuse, a ballast or other electrical equipment, or it could be a problem with the power source sending electricity to the light pole. The age of the lighting infrastructure along the interstates is a big factor, Kearley said.

See DARK | page 25



Jessica Maldonado and her family in front of her new coffee truck before the soft opening of Something Simple Coffee at The Preserve. Photo by Savannah Schmidt.

Hoover woman opens coffee truck

By LAUREN H. DOWDLE

There's nothing simple about starting a new business, especially for someone who is raising six children and works another job. But for Jessica Maldonado, simple is exactly what she was going for when she opened her mobile coffee and drinks truck in June.

Her truck, Something Simple Coffee + Sips, offers a variety of coffee, lemonade and energy refresher drinks at locations across Hoover and neighboring cities.

A Hoover native, Maldonado said she wanted to start her business here and continue planting roots in the community with her family, including her children: Reilly, 19; Mayah, 17; Madilyn, 8; Isabelle, 6; Sophia, 3; and Noah, 1. Her husband, Ignacio, is a detective with the Hoover Police Department, and Jessica will serve on the PTO board at Gwin Elementary School this year.

She has also formed connections through her time working as a server, shift lead and manager at various restaurants. Now an administrative assistant at J. Alexander's, she said that job has helped her learn more about the business aspect of running a restaurant, which made her wonder what else she could do with that experience.

INSIDE

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A new role

Brian Cocke has a vision for the Hoover City School arts program.



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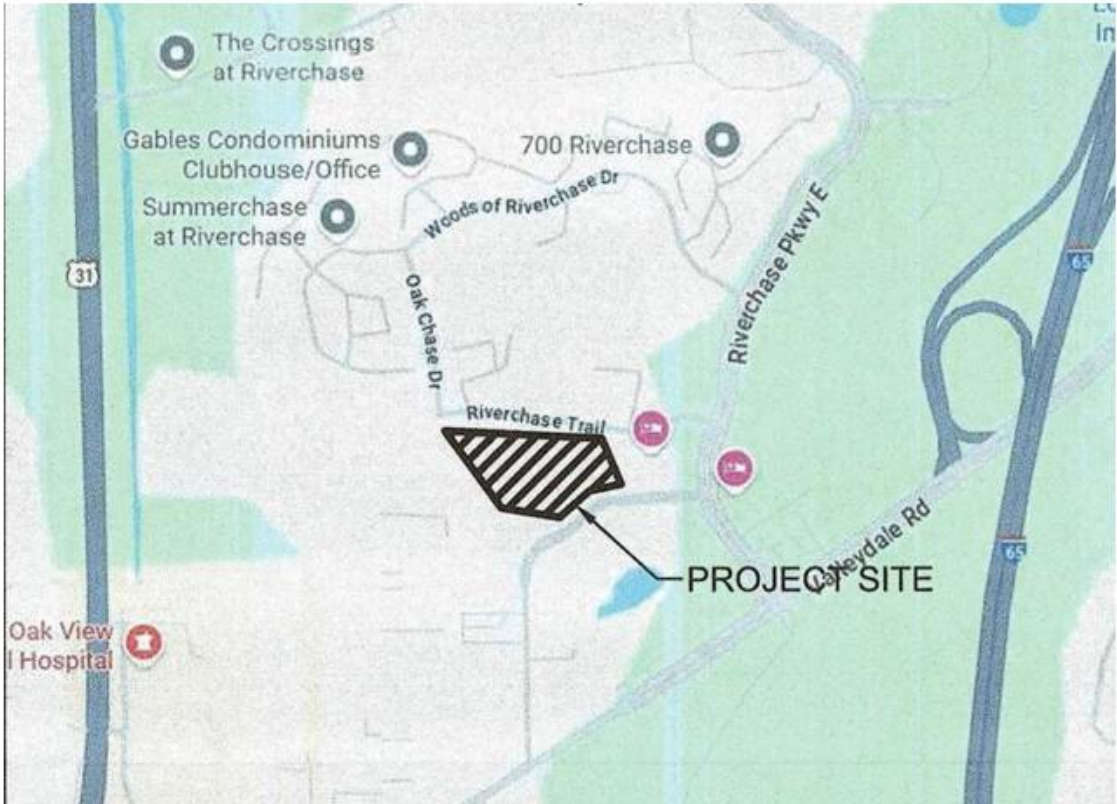
Driving in the dark: Hoover officials aim to fix interstate lighting woes



If you're driving on Interstate 459 or Interstate 65 in or around Hoover at night, there's a good chance you'll be driving in the dark. Many of the interstate streetlights are not working. Hoover officials said they try to keep an eye on outages and address them as they are reported, but there appear to be gaps in the process. On I-65 in early September, there were 23 interstate streetlights out on the southbound side between Alford Avenue and U.S. 31, three more out between U.S. 31

NEWS

Proposed Riverchase community center hits roadblock



A proposal for a new 30,000-square-foot community center in the Riverchase Office Park is running into snags. A group called the

NEWS

Hoover council approves \$206 million in government spending for 2027



The Hoover City Council on Monday night approved a 2027 budget that includes \$178 million in spending from the city’s general fund and a total of \$206 million in spending from all government funds. The \$178 million general fund budget represents a 4% increase from the original 2026 general fund budget. The council also approved \$10.4 million for capital projects and \$17.7 million in spending from special revenue accounts that include gas tax money and Municipal Court programs.

SPORTS

Week 7 Football Preview: Bucs, Jags with big region games



Week 6 is in the books, and the Under the Lights teams are back at it for Week 7. Region play returns this week after many teams took an

BUSINESSES

Hoover woman opens coffee truck



There’s nothing simple about starting a new business, especially for someone who is raising six children and works another job. But for Jessica Maldonado, simple is exactly what she was going for when she opened her mobile coffee and drinks truck in June. Her truck, Something Simple Coffee + Sips, offers a variety of coffee, lemonade and energy refresher drinks at locations across Hoover and neighboring cities. A Hoover native, Maldonado said she wanted to start her

PEOPLE

Hoover mom, business owner to compete for Mrs. America



Not only does Katie Guerin wear many hats — from mother and wife to business owner and community volunteer — but she also dons a variety of tiaras. A Hoover resident, Guerin has been competing in pageant scholarship programs across Alabama, Georgia and Florida since she was